had my head up, steeling myself, because there was trouble waiting for me as I trudged off the field.

Victoria had traveled over to Holland for the game. She'd obviously come to support me, but I remember feeling nervous about that before kick-off. We'd been told that our families would be seated in a secure, enclosed area but that hadn't happened. I looked across to see her in the crowd and, to be honest, I was worried about how safe Victoria was going to be. She was with her dad and they had trouble before and after the match, getting pushed around and abused by people who were calling themselves England supporters. She'll never go to a game like that, in those kinds of circumstances, ever again.

Some of those same idiots were waiting for me, too, when I came off the field. As I walked off towards the tunnel, after we'd been to applaud the England fans, there were five or six blokes, in seats behind the dugouts. They started having a go, first about me, then about Victoria. And then—the most horrible thing—they were shouting this stuff about Brooklyn. It still makes me feel sick to my stomach thinking about what they were saying. I was so angry; but I bit my lip. What can you do? You're powerless to stop it, aren't you? I just stuck my middle finger up towards them and headed straight down to the dressing room.

Since France 98, people having a go at me, inside and outside the grounds, had become something that happened so often that I'd almost learned to live with it. It always hurt but I got better at blocking it out, I suppose. What really shocked me was the abuse since Victoria and I had got married and started a family; instead of this earning us a little privacy and respect, it seemed to have made things worse. You'd have to ask the people who abused us why they did it. Envy? Contempt? Nothing better to do? All I do know is that, on that particular afternoon in Eindhoven, after I'd spent ninety minutes running round for the England team and we hadn't got a good result to show for it, my guard was definitely down. What those blokes said hurt and disgusted me and, because I was so shocked by it, I couldn't help but react.

By the time I'd gone down the tunnel with the rest of the team, the moment had gone as far as I was concerned. I was lucky that Kevin Keegan had been only a few paces behind me as we came off the field. He'd heard every word that had been screamed in my direction. He didn't mention it straight away in the dressing room. The more important thing was to talk about the game we'd just played and to start getting heads backup for the next